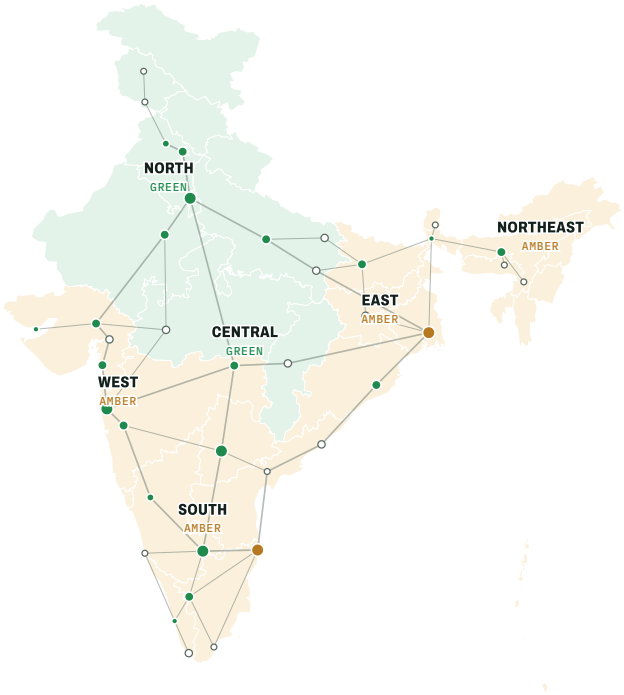
Flipkart's sale beats last year, and coal plants run short

NETWORK: AMBER

Flipkart's Big Billion Days ended with orders about a fifth above last year's, and its fastest-growing sellers were in Panipat, Bhiwadi, Tirupur and Hisar. Half of India's coal power plants hold under three days' fuel, so the coal trains stay on power duty. Chennai is waterlogged again, and JNPA's queue for inland trains has finally eased.

HOW'S EACH REGION HOLDING UP?



Map: DataMeet, CC BY 4.0

DATES TO WATCH

22–24 Oct	Kolkata immersion bans on goods vehicles
Thu 22 Oct	NH-202 Imphal–Ukhrul shutdown ends
22–23 Oct	NH-85 Adimali–Munnar shut
22–24 Oct	Petrapole–Benapole shut to cargo
22–24 Oct	Air India and IndiGo Saudi flights cancelled
22–25 Oct	Heavy rain in Tamil Nadu and Kerala
Fri 23 Oct	Farmers plan to block the Bengaluru–Mysuru highway
Fri 23 Oct	Second low likely over the southeast Bay
26–27 Oct	Kolkata immersion bans, second round
26 Oct–5 Nov	NH-10 night closures
Sun 1 Nov	Delhi keeps out non-BS-VI vehicles from outside
Sun 1 Nov	CMA CGM's new North Europe–India rates
Sun 1 Nov	Ethanol year starts without sugar-based ethanol

GREEN the sale season as usual, which can still be busy

AMBER something beyond the season is slowing freight

RED something is stopping freight across a state or a route

North

GREEN

The air commission put Delhi and the NCR under the first stage of GRAP on Wednesday as the air turned poor[1]. Trucks not bound for Delhi are sent round by the Eastern and Western Peripheral Expressways, the usual October routing, and trucks for the city still get in, so there's no delay beyond the season.

West

AMBER

JNPA's import boxes waiting for inland trains fell to 3,975 TEU in Wednesday's report, from 4,349 a day earlier, and those waiting for the freight stations to 10,405 from 14,409[2,3]. That's the first real dent in a week. The rail queue is still well above where it stood in mid-October, mind you. I'd expect boxes landing this week to reach their inland depots two days late, and the queue to be near normal by the middle of next week.

South

AMBER

Rain from Tuesday night flooded T Nagar, Velachery and other parts of Chennai, and the corporation's pumps took hours to clear each road, The News Minute reports[4]. The low that formed on Wednesday morning will soak both states till Sunday, IMD says[5]. I'd expect Chennai's deliveries to run a day late till Saturday, and loads for Coimbatore and the Nilgiris to slow on Friday, when the heaviest rain moves there[6].

East

AMBER

Immersions run from Wednesday to the 24th in Kolkata, Howrah, Barrackpore and Chandannagar, with 18 senior police officers and extra forces on the routes, ETV Bharat reports[7]. Goods vehicles stay off the city's roads on those nights under the police plan, and again on the 26th and 27th[8]. I'd expect city loads to wait at the edge-of-town hubs on those nights, and Kolkata's deliveries to run a day late till the 28th.

Northeast

AMBER

The Imphal valley's 48-hour bandh ended on Wednesday with its markets still deserted, and Kangpokpi, on the Dimapur road into Imphal, shut for a bandh of its own the same day, Outlook India reports[9]. I'd expect loads held at Dimapur and Jiribam to roll from today and reach Imphal a day or two late, by the weekend.

Central

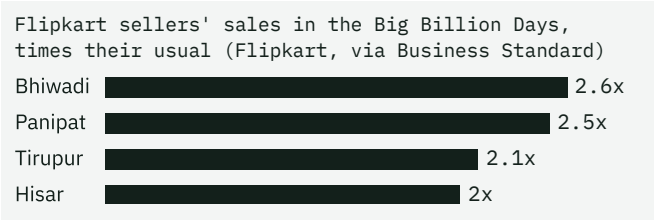
GREEN

No delay beyond the season in the centre this week.

NETWORK INSIGHTS

1 Flipkart's sale ends with orders a fifth above last year's

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE



Flipkart's Big Billion Days ended with orders, units and buyers each up about 20-22% on last year, by the company's figures in Business Standard[10]. Its sellers in Bhiwadi, Panipat, Tirupur and Hisar sold two to 2.6 times their usual, and Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Nagpur, Jabalpur and Meerut were among its fastest-growing buyer towns[10]. Amazon, of course, is still on sale, and says its sellers sold 3.5 times their normal in the first week, with over 70% of the small ones from smaller cities[11]. What does that do to the network? It loads the first mile out of manufacturing towns, and the long haul into towns with no big hub of their own. Amazon's delivery complaints rose too: 39 of its 218 Play Store reviews on the 20th, against 19 of 196 the day before[12]. I'd expect the last of Flipkart's sale orders to reach Nagpur, Jabalpur and Meerut by the weekend, with Amazon's sale still running on top.

> **Brands selling online that ship from Panipat, Tirupur or Bhiwadi lean on a first mile running at twice its usual load, so one missed pickup costs them a day. Carriers and 3PLs carry the long haul into Nagpur, Jabalpur and Meerut, where a late truck misses the next morning's delivery run.**

2 Navratri car registrations fall 22%, and commercial vehicles rise only 1%

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

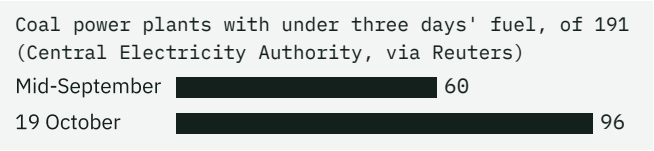
Vehicle registrations fell 6.5% this Navratri to 1.12 million, with cars down 21.9% to 183,000, by FADA's provisional count in Millennium Post[13]. Commercial vehicles were one of only two kinds to grow, by 1.1%, to 35,618[13]. Maruti Suzuki says its deliveries were about 98% of last year's, held back by how many cars it can make, PSU Watch reports from PTI[14]. So the car carriers out of the plants run close to last year's loads. The commercial vehicles are the bit that worries me: about 36,000 new ones in ten days, trucks among them, add little room to lanes carrying the festive peak. I'd expect truck hire on those lanes to stay tight, and dear, until Diwali on 8th November.

> **Carriers and 3PLs that hire market trucks for the Diwali peak will pay more for each one, because the fleet is barely growing. Manufacturers and brands selling online that book trucks late in the season face the tightest hire and the highest cost.**

3 Half of India's coal power plants hold under three days' fuel

Coal by rail to power plants, and the open wagons other industry waits for

AMBER · HIGH COST OF DELAY · MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

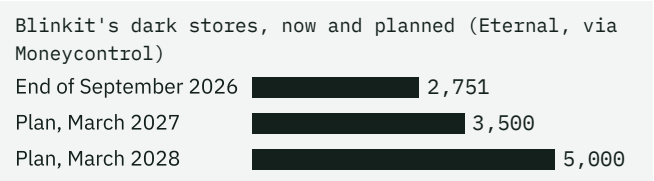


Half of India's 191 coal power plants held under three days' coal on 19 October, 96 against 60 in mid-September, while total stocks fell about 5% this month, Reuters reports from Central Electricity Authority data[15]. Why so short? A weak monsoon cut hydro power by a fifth in September, and the plants are making up for it[15]. Gujarat's demand hit a record 29,822 MW on the 16th. The state says the coal ministry has promised it 10 to 11 coal trains a day until November, and 13 to 14 after that, The Times of India reports[16]. I'd expect power plants to keep first call on the open wagons into November, so that cement and steel loads using the same wagons wait longer for a train or go by road.

> **Manufacturers that send cement, steel or coal by rail can expect longer waits for wagons into November, and some will pay road rates to keep plants supplied. Carriers and 3PLs with trucks in Gujarat and the coal belt get that overflow, at road rates, just as Diwali loads peak.**

4 Blinkit plans 750 more dark stores by March, most of the push in smaller cities

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE



Blinkit added 308 dark stores in the September quarter to reach 2,751, and now plans 3,500 by March 2027 and 5,000 a year after that, Moneycontrol reports from Eternal's results[17]. Its order value grew 79% on last year, to ₹20,940 crore, BusinessLine reports[18]. And where do the new stores go? Into smaller cities, where its chief Albinder Dhindsa says he is most bullish[18]. About 750 stores in five months is roughly five a day. My guess is each one needs a daily stock run from a regional warehouse. So I'd expect demand for short-haul trucks and city warehouse space outside the metros to climb through the winter, after Diwali.

> **Carriers and 3PLs that run warehouse-to-store trucks get new daily lanes outside the metros, with small loads per drop that cost more to serve. Brands selling through quick commerce will need stock placed in more regional warehouses, a working-capital cost that grows with every city added.**

THE LANES I'M WATCHING

NH-85 Adimali–Munnar

● AMBER

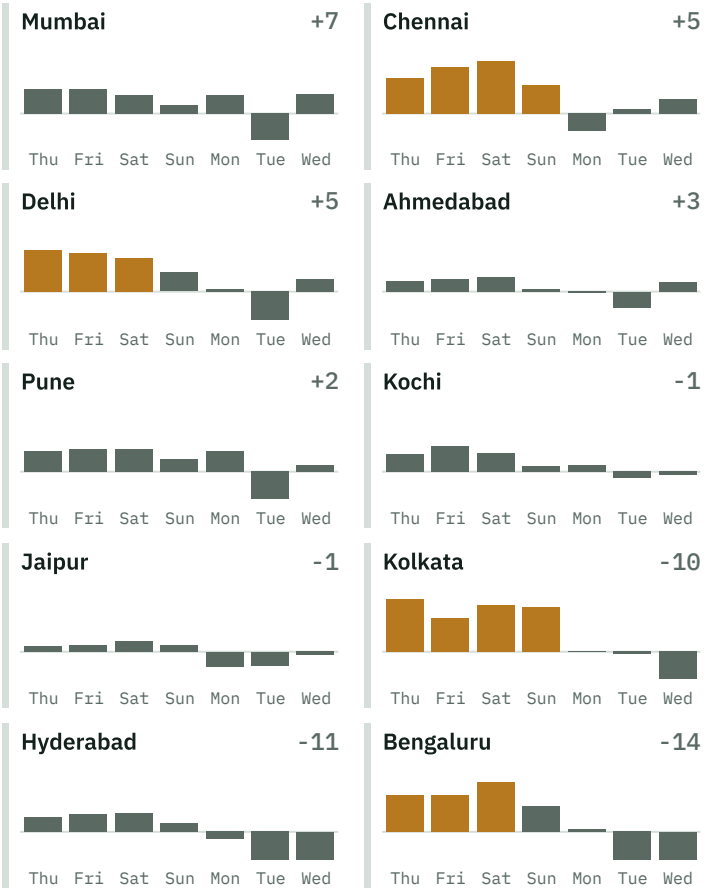
SHUT AT RANDAAM MILE WHILE THE SLOPE IS CLEARED

Idukki's administration has kept the stretch at Randaam Mile closed since Monday's rockfall while the slope is made safe, Mathrubhumi reports[19]. Freight for the hill town is going round by the longer Anachal route, so I'd expect Munnar's shops and estates to get their loads half a day late into the weekend.

CITY TRAFFIC UPDATES

City roads against usual, daily, 15–21 Oct[20] amber = 10+ over

Kolkata ran well over usual through the Puja, with roads round the pandals closed under the police plan[8], and Chennai through the heavy rain of the 16th to 18th[21]. Bengaluru did as the Dasara crowd drove out of town[22], and Delhi in the evenings round the Ramlila and Puja grounds, as its traffic police had warned[23].



HOW MY CALLS HAVE DONE

Of the 5 calls scored so far, 4 came true, 1 partly and none was wrong. 4 are still open. From 12 Oct:

1. The state retailers hold diesel prices through 19th October, while Jio-bp's and Nayara's stay ₹3 a litre higher. **Right.** No change reported at the state pumps; Nayara and Jio-bp charge ₹3 more. Source
2. Delhi's BS-IV exemption has not been extended by 19th October. **Right.** Gurugram police confirmed the 1 November cut-off on the 16th. Source

HOW THIS IS MADE

At 7 every morning, Claude drafts this page on its own using data available from public sources only. It reads the morning's public signals: city traffic in ten cities, the JNPA and Paradip port reports, ship queues at the container ports, toll-plaza truck counts, the seasonal calendar and about twenty news searches.

Then it writes, and a set of checks decides whether the draft is even fit for me to read. Every claim has to be opened and cited, and no source can be over a week old without a reason. No story from the last seven days comes back unless it actually moved, and nothing gets said twice.

I read it, argue with it, fix what's wrong and approve it. The ratings are my judgement on the likelihood of on-time delivery or cost-impact, not measured service levels or actual cost estimates. Confidence is High when the facts are dated and primary or measured, Medium when they rest on a proxy or a forecast. Does that make the page right? Not always, which is why the calls get scored.

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SOURCES

1. Mint: GRAP 1 restrictions in Delhi, impact on cars and trucks, 21 Oct
2. JNPA daily status report, 21 Oct
3. JNPA daily status report, 20 Oct
4. The News Minute: Chennai rains, T Nagar, Velachery and other areas face waterlogging, 21 Oct
5. IMD press release: low over the southwest Bay, heavy to very heavy rain over Tamil Nadu and Kerala, 21 Oct
6. New Indian Express: low-pressure area forms over the Bay of Bengal, 21 Oct
7. ETV Bharat: senior IPS officers to oversee Durga idol immersions in Kolkata and other places, 21 Oct
8. Millennium Post: Kolkata Puja traffic plan, 5 Oct
9. Outlook India: Manipur shutdowns hit Kangpokpi and the Imphal valley, 21 Oct
10. Business Standard: Flipkart's Big Billion Days draws 9 in 10 shoppers as orders rise 20-22%, 21 Oct
11. Deccan Herald: Amazon festive sales, small sellers from Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities drive growth, 21 Oct
12. Google Play: Amazon reviews about delivery, to 21 Oct
13. Millennium Post: vehicle registrations decline 6.5% during Navratri, FADA, 21 Oct
14. PSU Watch (PTI): Navratri vehicle sales fall 6.5% as passenger vehicle registrations plunge 22%, 21 Oct
15. Business Standard (Reuters): half of coal plants run critically low on fuel as power demand surges, 21 Oct
16. Times of India: Gujarat secures extra coal supply as power demand spikes, 21 Oct
17. Moneycontrol: Blinkit steps up expansion, targets 3,500 dark stores by March 2027, 21 Oct
18. BusinessLine: Eternal Q2 net profit up 92%, revenue up 77%, 21 Oct
19. Mathrubhumi: Adimali–Munnar road shut for three days after a boulder falls on NH-85, 20 Oct

20. TomTom Traffic Index, ten cities
21. IMD press release: extremely heavy rain over Tamil Nadu, 18 Oct
22. Deccan Herald: Dasara rush leaves Bengaluru motorists stranded for six hours, 17 Oct
23. Business Today: Delhi traffic police warn of evening delays till 20 Oct, 17 Oct